Mobile UX Prototyping, UXD-M
Exercise, Winter term 2026/27

Exercise Sheet 01
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Claims and their sources · Patterns as a language

What is this sheet about?

This sheet brings together the two topics that open the term: *Claims and their sources* and *Patterns as a language*. You apply both to one and the same app from this week's top charts – first to the market claims that surround it, then to the patterns inside it. Every claim is hunted back to its oldest reachable source, and every pattern verdict names its price.

Everything you need for the pattern half is on this sheet: the definition, the four families with their core patterns, the reference works and the three legitimate reasons to break a pattern. The MUXP.1 group works this sheet *before* the lecture on *Patterns as a language*, so nothing here assumes that session.

Organisation: Work in teams of three, four only if the numbers do not divide. In the pattern dissection, each of you takes one pattern family: navigation, forms and feedback in a team of three, plus search in a team of four.

On this sheet, the letters A, B, C and D stand for the pattern families. Settle who carries which letter before the first assignment; a team of three has no D and leaves search out.

What you take with you: At the end of the session, **every person** holds a claim check (assignment 2) and a dissection of the family or families they took (assignment 3) of their own. The team writes the synthesis (assignment 4) once, and every member keeps a copy. The sheet has no upload of its own. Its results are the content of **Part A**, your first graded presentation (see the end of this sheet); they count again in **Part C**, and they go into your **seminar paper**.

First assignment (15 minutes): Choose your target app from the list announced in the session (taken from this week's top charts); if no list is announced, take any app from the current top 20 of your store, and no two teams take the same app. The letters correspond to the four pattern families: (A) *navigation*, (B) *forms*, (C) *feedback*, (D) *search*.

Then collect the claims that surround your app: open its App Store or Play Store page, the vendor's press section and one aggregator article about the app or its market. Collect at least four market claims as verbatim quotes (with where you found them). You will need them in the second assignment, so do not judge them yet.

Second assignment (45 minutes): Each team member picks *one* of the collected market claims (each member a different one) and performs a complete claim check.

- **The claim,** quoted verbatim, with where you found it.
- **The source chain:** hunt the claim to the oldest origin you can reach. Note every station (primary source, secondary use, aggregator) with year and publisher.
- **Your verdict** (*supported / supportable / unsupportable*), argued with the three-part criterion from Topic 1: measurer, year, population. A verdict of *"plausible"* does not count.
- **The flip condition:** *"My verdict changes if …"* One sentence that a concrete finding could actually falsify, as in the *Label the claim* activity of Topic 1.

AI role: tool. Models are allowed and encouraged for the source hunt. Note what you asked, and watch what they hand you as *"sources"*: that observation is part of the exercise.

Pattern vocabulary for this sheet

A pattern is a named, recurring solution to a recurring design problem – proven by use, not by argument. The name lets a team argue about a screen instead of pointing at it. *Recurring* means that problem and solution return across thousands of apps; a trick used in a single app gets no name. And *proven by use* is what separates a pattern from a style guide, which justifies its rules on paper, and from taste.

Where pattern names come from. Four reference works, and you name which one you used:

- **Tidwell**, *Designing Interfaces* – the classic catalogue of interface patterns with established names.
- **Apple Human Interface Guidelines (HIG)** – Apple's platform contract, and the naming authority for iOS.
- **Material 3** – Google's platform contract, and the naming authority for Android.
- **Mobbin** – a collection of current app screens, sorted into categories; useful where the two platform contracts have no term.

The four families and their core patterns. These are the patterns you will most often find; the list is not exhaustive, and a pattern outside it is a legitimate answer if you name its source.

- **(A) Navigation** – *tab bar* (everything visible, at most five destinations, paid for in screen space), *navigation drawer* (hides and scales: room for twenty entries, at the price that nobody sees them), *hub & spoke* (every route through the center: clean separation, slow switching), *sequential flow* (one step at a time, the shape of checkout and onboarding).
- **(B) Forms** – *inline validation* (the form checks each field while you type, and the error appears where it happens), *input-appropriate keyboards* (a number field opens the number pad), *progressive disclosure* (ask later what you do not need now).
- **(C) Feedback** – *optimistic UI* (acts as if it worked and repairs if it did not: the message shows as sent before the server confirms), *skeleton screens* (show the shape of what is coming; a gray placeholder feels faster than a spinner over nothing), *undo over confirm* (act first, offer reversal, skip the "Are you sure?" – but only where reversal is actually possible), *error messages* in plain language that name the problem and suggest a way out, on the screen rather than in a modal.
- **(D) Search** – *type-ahead* (suggests while the user is still typing, because steering a query beats repairing one), *scoped search* (search where the user already stands before searching everything), *zero-results recovery* (an empty list is a dead end; a good zero state loosens the filter, fixes the typo, offers the neighbour category).

The three legitimate reasons to break a pattern – and there is no fourth. Every legitimate break points to something that changed: the device, the gesture, or the message.

1. **A new device class** where the pattern never fitted – smartwatch navigation could not inherit the tab bar.
2. **A new gesture or capability** that makes a pattern obsolete – system-wide swipe gestures demoted the back button.
3. **Deliberate contrast**, the rarest and riskiest reason: the break *is* the message.

The fourth reason, the one that is not legitimate, is that nobody thought about it – and from outside that can look exactly like courage. The difference shows in the price: whoever broke a pattern without thinking cannot name what it cost.

Third assignment (60 minutes): Now turn to the patterns inside the app. Each team member dissects the pattern family they took by operating the app on a device; screenshots only document what you found: (A) navigation, (B) forms, (C) feedback, (D) search.

Start from the guiding question of your family (or of each of your two):

- **(A) Navigation:** how well does the navigation support orientation, consistency and efficient movement within the app?
- **(B) Forms:** how simple and logical are the forms in layout, validation and error prevention? Look for duplicated fields, password rules shown only after a failed attempt, and placeholders that disappear while the user types.
- **(C) Feedback:** how clear is the feedback in errors, confirmations and progress? An error message names the problem in plain language, suggests a way out and appears on the screen where the problem is.
- **(D) Search:** how relevant are the results, and do filters and suggestions help?

For each family you took, document:

- **The dominant pattern,** named with a Tidwell term, an HIG or Material 3 term, or a Mobbin category – see the vocabulary above. State which source you used.
- **One recognition feature:** *"I recognize it by …"* in one sentence.
- **One deviation,** if any: where does the app break the established pattern? Give your verdict (*innovation / error*) **and its price**, one sentence each. Check the verdict against the three legitimate reasons listed above: a new device class, a new gesture or capability, deliberate contrast. If none of them applies, say so – that is the fourth reason, and it is not a defence. If your family shows no deviation, write exactly that down; it is a finding, too.

Add screenshots where they carry your argument. **AI as sparring partner is allowed** (naming checks: *"What is this pattern called?"*), but the verdicts must be yours.

Fourth assignment (45 minutes): Bring the two halves of this sheet together in your team. Put the four family dissections and the checked claims side by side and discuss the following guiding questions:

- Where does the app break a pattern, and does any of the checked claims support the break as an intentional decision?
- Which of the four verdicts (*innovation / error*) would change if the shakiest claim turned out to be unsupportable?
- Which claim would the vendor have to support with evidence before you would copy this app's pattern break in your own project?

Condense your discussion into a one-page team profile of the app: the strongest evidence-backed statement you can make about it, the shakiest claim that surrounds it, and the one pattern decision you would defend in front of a client, with a source.

Keep your claim check, your family dissection and the team profile, marked with the team's names. Exercise sheet 02 returns to the same app, and the claim check is the evidence discipline that Parts A, B and C and the seminar paper ask of every number you use.

Part A: this sheet in 15 minutes

The results of this sheet are the content of Part A, the first graded part of the presentation (20 points): 15 minutes in your team with the lecturer, with **10 content slides** (title slide, outline and closing slide do not count). Upload your presentation by **Fri 23 Oct**; you present it within your own group's session of **Exercise U2** (26 Oct for MUXP.1, 2 Nov for MUXP.2). The fifteen minutes carry what assignments 1 to 4 produced:

- **The app** and the market claims that surround it (assignment 1).
- **Each member's claim check:** the source chain to the oldest origin you reached, the verdict argued along measurer, year and population, and the flip condition (assignment 2).
- **Each family dissection:** the dominant pattern with its source, the recognition feature, and the deviation with verdict and price – or the finding that there is none (assignment 3).
- **The team profile:** the strongest evidence-backed statement about the app, the shakiest claim around it, and the one pattern decision you would defend in front of a client, with a source (assignment 4).

After Part A, this sheet stays in play: it counts again in **Part C**, the final presentation, where the whole exercise track U1–U5 is relevant, and it goes into your **seminar paper**, as all five sheets do. How Part A is graded – content, presentation and discussion, with three guiding questions each – is set out in the **assessment criteria** (PDF in Moodle).